

Activities that (you might not realise) are ways into improvising

Copy me rhythms

Ask your student to make up (improvise) their own 4 beat rhythm for you (tutor) or another student to copy back.

Once your students are confident improvising 4 beat rhythms, try extending them to 8 beat rhythms.

Rhythm chains

Ask student 1 to make up (improvise) their own 4 beat rhythm.

Ask student 2 to copy this rhythm and then add their own 4 beat rhythm creating an 8 beat pattern.

Ask student 3 (or go back to 1 if this is a paired lesson) to play the rhythms by students 1 and 2 before adding their own.

How long can your rhythm chain get?

These activities will help to develop both rhythmic improvisation skills and aural recall skills.

Same scale - new rhythm

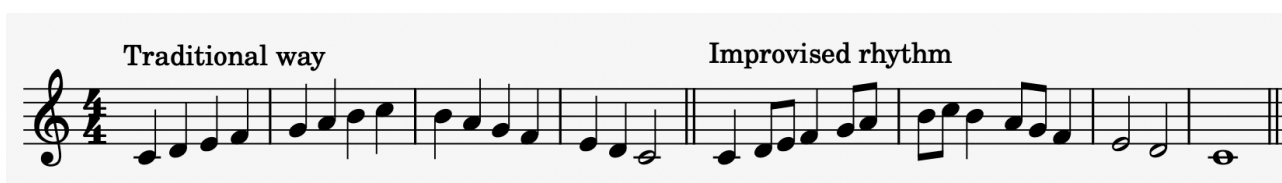
Ask your students to play their scales using an improvised rhythm.

Example -



Question and answer phrases

Improvise a Question phrase and ask your student to improvise an Answering phrase. If you use the scale from the previous activity this becomes a nice development idea and way to embed the notes of the scale.



Ear training

Encourage your students to learn to play a simple tune by ear e.g. a nursery rhyme and then see if they can transpose it into a new key (from a new starting point)



The image shows two musical staves for the nursery rhyme 'Twinkle, twinkle little star' in 4/4 time. The first staff is titled 'Twinkle, twinkle little star in C' and the second is titled 'Twinkle, twinkle little star in F'. Both staves show the melody line with notes and rests.

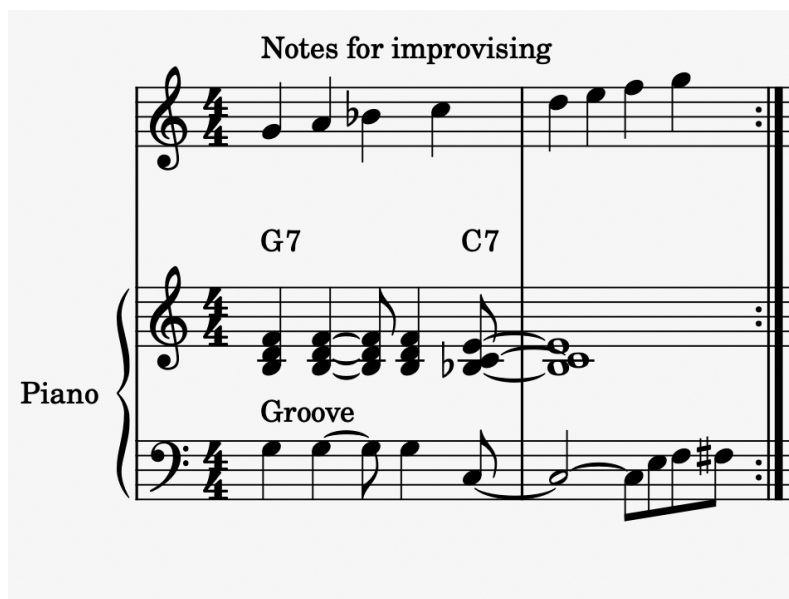
Same tune - new chords

If you teach the piano encourage your students to re-harmonise a simple tune by changing the chords e.g. see what happens if you make a major chord, minor or add a 7th to it? The re-harmonisation might not work but it gives your students the opportunity to explore harmony and the idea of tension and release. Why did the composer choose a certain chord? Can your students suggest chords that might work e.g. if there is a C in the melody line then the chord could be C major, C minor, F major, F minor or A minor.

Groove

Play a simple groove on the piano or guitar (or use a backing track) and play Q and A phrases with your students.

Example -



The image shows a musical score for improvisation. The top staff is titled 'Notes for improvising' and shows a melody line in 4/4 time. The bottom two staves are labeled 'Piano' and show a 'Groove' in 4/4 time. The groove consists of a bass line and a treble line. Chords G7 and C7 are indicated above the piano part. The score includes repeat signs and a double bar line at the end.